

traditional votebank of the Congress and NCP in rural areas.

Formed over a month ago, the Third Front has managed to unite multiple factions of the Republican Party of India (RPI), which represents the Dalits and other marginalised sections in the state. Joining hands with the RPI are the Peasants and Workers Party (PWP), Communist Party of India (Marxist), Communist Party of India, Samajwadi Party (SP), Janata Dal (Secular), Lok Bharati, sss, Socialist Front, Lok Janshakti Party, Rashtriya Samaj Paksha, Samajwadi Jan Parishad, Socialist Front and Satyashodhak Communist Party.

From the look of it, the Congress-NCP combine has reasons to worry because the DF's tally has been coming down. In the last Assembly elections in 2004, the independents and other smaller parties won 30 seats, while the DF bagged 139 seats against the Shiv Sena-BJP's 119. The NCP had emerged as the single largest group with 71 legislators, followed by the Congress with 69, the Shiv Sena with 62 and the BJP which got 54. However, the DF's tally has come down from 151 in the 1999 elections to 139 seats in 2004. The rise of the local parties has also eaten into the vote-share of the Sena and the BJP. The saffron combine's tally slipped to 119 in 2004 from 136 in 1999. While in 1999 only one seat went to a non-allied party, in the 2004 polls as many as 30 candidates won as independents or represented smaller parties.

What makes the Third Front interesting is that these are not traditional political outfits but mainly local movements which have come into existence to lend a voice to those who have not been heard. For instance, the Republican Party of India-Athavale, which is led by Dalit

leader Ramdas Athavale, has been a Congress ally for 19 years. Despite this, Congress workers worked against Athavale in Shirdi during the Lok Sabha elections, leading to his defeat in the elections. "The Third Front represents all segments of society that have been marginalised. We have been with the Congress for 19 years but weren't getting any recognition. They give us token posts but don't let us grow," he says. The Third Front is targeting 12 per cent of the electorate which does not have any ideological leanings, even as Dalits form 6 per cent of the state's population.

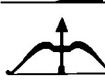
India may have witnessed spectacular growth in the last decade, but the growth has not been inclusive for the marginalised segments in Maharashtra. Having handed over key portfolios to the NCP, the Congress has been out of the driving seat as far



A CONGLOMERATION OF 18 PARTIES, THE THIRD Front is banking heavily on the Dalit votebank and targeting 12 per cent of the electorate in the state.

as governance is concerned, resulting in much pain to the rural masses. Citing this as the biggest reason for his entry into politics, Raju Shetti says that the farmers in the sugar-rich belt of western Maharashtra have been reduced to slavery, as the sugar cooperatives and banks are all run by rich politicians and their families as private enterprises.

Based in Kolhapur district of Maharashtra, Shetti's sss has sent ripples in the bastions of sugar barons and made them raise the sugarcane price from a pittance to about Rs 1,300. Says Shetti: "With rapid urbanisation, the attention will shift from rural to urban and we will suffer more. We need representation in the Assembly." The Third Front is aiming for 40 seats of the 288.

MAHARASHTRA		Total Seats 288	
PARTIES		SEATS 2004	Vote Share %
	Indian National Congress	69	21.1
	Bharatiya Janata Party	54	13.7
	Communist Party of India (Marxist)	3	0.6
	Nationalist Congress Party	71	18.8
	Shiv Sena	62	20.1
Independents and others		29	25.7

The RLDF is contesting for the first time.